WAYANAD BYPOLLS

PRIYANKA'S CHARM OFFENSIVE

By Jeemon Jacob



NEXT UP Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Vadra at the roadshow in Kalpetta, Oct. 23

Wayanad welcomed Congress candidate Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on October 23 with music and dance, her fans, young and old, stepping to the tune of the drums. Thousands of Congress workers had descended on Kalpetta, the district headquarters of scenic Wayanad, to greet the Gandhi scion and see her in action.

Priyanka, accompanied by husband Robert Vadra, their children Raihan and Mirayan and mother Sonia Gandhi, had reached Sultan Bathery in Wayanad from Mysuru by road the previous night. Hundreds of people were waiting by the roadside to greet her in the night, necessitating a number of stops so that she could interact with the crowd. One of the pitstops also led to an impromptu visit to the home of a local, Karumankulam Thresiya Papachan, after her ex-armyman son Binoy mentioned that his mother was a big fan but couldn't come down to the road as she was bedridden. Priyanka spent 20 minutes with the family, but it was enough to make page one flyers in the dailies the next day.

Meanwhile, on the day of the nomination, the roadshow began at noon from Kalpetta bus terminal. This time, Priyanka had for company her brother Rahul Gandhi, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and the who's who of the state Congress. Later, during an emotional speech, she touched on how her life as a campaigner started in 1989 for her late father, Rajiv Gandhi. Themn, she told the crowd: "Whatever the issue, I'll be with you if you give me a chance to serve you. My brother has explained the problems you face and your struggles. but I want to come to your house and understand from you what they are. You are my guide and my teacher on this journey."

Wayanad is not new ground for the Gandhis. Rahul won from here in the past two Lok Sabha elections, in fact the seat was a saving grace in 2019 after Smriti Irani's spirited campaign in Amethi presaged a certain defeat. The constituency, encompassing the Kozhikode, Malappuram and Wayanad districts, has a big minority community element (42 per cent Muslim and 14 per cent Christian) and has been a safe seat for the Congress. Rahul had won from here and Raebareli but preferred to retain the family bastion in Uttar Pradesh.

So, will the mantle pass on seamlessly to his sister now? Well, the Congress state unit is certainly gearing up to ensure a win for their prize candidate. "We want to give her more than half a million [votes]," leader of the Opposition V.D. Satheeshan told INDIA TODAY. "Wayanad is Congress territory and there is a strong anti-incumbency factor against the ruling Left Front government in the state. We have already held seven assembly conventions in the constituency. We want to create political history in Kerala with the largest winning margin."

The Left Front has fielded an old hand, 71-year-old Sathyan Mokeri of the Communist Party of India (CPI), whose connections with Wayanad go back to his student days. "We will fight the polls on the basis of issues, not on the basis of who our political opponents are," says Mokeri. The BJP had tried to rope in actress and party spokesperson Khushbu,

AT A GLANCE

- **A Congress fort, the Wayanad LS seat includes Kozhikode, Malappuram, Wayanad districts**
- **It has some 1.3 mn voters; 58% are minorities**
- **The Left has fielded CPI veteran Sathyan Mokeri, the BJP ex-software engineer Navya Haridas**
- **Wayanad has had a hard time of late, the July landslides that killed 550 people being the latest**